

Question Design Rationale: Deathcare Digital Maturity Assessment

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Every question in the tool asks about a system or process an outside assessor could verify by watching one case go from first call to aftercare. None asks about intent. Each answer ladder follows the same five-step logic: nothing in place, informal or manual, defined at one location, managed across the network, then optimizing and feeding other capabilities. A respondent can place themselves by asking "is this fully true today?" without guessing which answer is "right." Every question also has to separate homes within deathcare. Almost every home has a phone and some web presence, so we avoided questions every home would answer the same way.

Case & Records Infrastructure. The deathcare case file is legally consequential: it holds permits, the death certificate and often a preneed contract sold years earlier. We therefore anchored the dimension on three moments where record quality is exposed. First is how the case file is created. Second is how the death certificate reaches the state, which moves from in-person filing to fax, to manual EDRS entry, to EDRS integrated with case management. Third is whether an old preneed contract can be found when the death occurs, including one sold at another location. That last question separates single-location homes from real networks. A fourth question on record ownership tests governance rather than software.

Family Digital Engagement. A website is not diagnostic in this industry; what a family can do on it is. The website question climbs from a phone listing to completing the whole arrangement and a preneed purchase online, the model direct-to-consumer providers like Tulip Cremation use. Livestreaming became standard after 2020 but is delivered very differently: ad hoc, on request, by default, or archived into a tribute page. Payment and aftercare round out the family journey. Aftercare matters because the relationship after the service drives referrals and preneed sales.

Operational Automation. We picked the three back-office workflows unique to funeral service: scheduling staff and removal vehicles, casket and urn inventory, and life-insurance assignments. Assignments are a strong discriminator because some homes still mail paper forms to carriers while large operators track them on dashboards. The fourth question asks whether automation opportunities are found systematically, which separates a home that bought one tool from one that keeps improving.

Predictive & AI Deployment. Forecasting case volume is the most realistic first AI use in deathcare, so it anchors the dimension. Because families are grieving, we added a question found in no generic model: whether family-facing AI output is reviewed for tone and sensitivity, and whether that review decides if the tool stays. The other two questions separate a monitored production tool from an unmonitored website chatbot, and a strategy-led roadmap from buying whatever a vendor pitches.

Organizational Change Capacity. Funeral directors are the product; families trust a person, not a system. The questions therefore ask whether directors are involved in technology decisions, how they are trained, and whether a dedicated change role exists. The strongest discriminator is whether the old paper process is actually retired. Keeping paper files "just in case" is the most common sign of a stalled rollout in this industry, and anyone can see it.

Testing. We simulated a Stage 2 home (scores 1.5–2.25) and a Stage 4 network (3.75–4.25). They produced visibly different radar shapes and different profiles, *The Traditional Home* versus *Digital-Native Network*, and each gap pattern in the Interpretation Guide was reproduced on purpose.

Interpretation Guide

How the tool scores. Every answer option carries an integer value from 1 to 5. Each dimension score is the plain average of its four answers, so scores fall on quarter steps (1.00, 1.25 ... 5.00). The results panel always names the two lowest-scoring dimensions. If two or more dimensions tie for lowest, it names all of them, and it never breaks a tie by list order. It then chooses **one** profile using the rules below.

Profile selection order.

1. If every dimension is $\leq 2.5 \rightarrow$ *The Traditional Home*.
2. Otherwise, if every dimension is $\geq 3.5 \rightarrow$ *Digital-Native Network*.
3. Otherwise, each single-dimension gap pattern whose condition holds is a candidate. The dimension must be "among the lowest," meaning at or below the second-lowest score, so ties at the cutoff count. If several apply, the one on the **lowest-scoring dimension** wins. Next comes the **largest gap below the others**, and finally the industry priority *Records $\rightarrow$ Change $\rightarrow$ AI*: in deathcare, broken records create legal and compliance risk before anything else.
4. If nothing matches $\rightarrow$ *No Dominant Pattern* (fallback).

The names, patterns, descriptions and actions below match the tool's PROFILES data word for word.

1. The Traditional Home: uniformly low

Pattern: Every dimension scores 2.5 or below (the Stage 1–2 band).

The organization hasn't built the basic case-management or family-facing infrastructure that later-stage capability depends on. Investing in AI or forecasting tools now would be premature.

Next action: Build a real case management system and basic family-facing website and obituary tools first.

2. Digital-Native Network: uniformly high

Pattern: Every dimension scores 3.5 or above (solidly Stage 4 or better).

Real capability across the board, but in this industry the risk isn't a capability gap; it's over-automating a business whose actual product is a trusted human relationship during grief. The next frontier is judgment rather than more technology: using the unified family record to time and personalize aftercare and preneed outreach in ways grieving families welcome.

Next action: Benchmark family satisfaction, not just efficiency metrics, against peer networks to check whether automation has quietly eroded the personal touch.

3. Elegant Front, Broken Back Office: Case & Records Infrastructure lags

Pattern: Case & Records Infrastructure is among the lowest-scoring dimensions and at least 1.0 point below the average of the other four.

Even where family-facing tools exist, the case records underneath are fragmented. That creates real legal and compliance risk (misfiled permits, lost preneed contracts) and undermines any forecasting or AI built on top of those records.

Next action: Fix records infrastructure before any further family-facing or AI investment.

4. Digitalized but Not Predictive: high Family Digital Engagement, low AI

Pattern: Family Digital Engagement scores 4.0 or above, while Predictive & AI Deployment scores 2.5 or below and is among the lowest-scoring dimensions.

Families get a modern digital experience (livestream, online obituary, digital payment), but nothing behind the scenes uses forecasting or engagement intelligence. It's a nicer surface on the same underlying operations.

Next action: Pilot a case-volume forecasting tool to inform staffing before adding more family-facing features.

5. Technology Nobody Asked For: the execution gap

Pattern: Organizational Change Capacity is among the lowest-scoring dimensions and at least 1.0 point below the average of the other four.

Family trust depends on funeral directors feeling ownership over how technology touches grieving families. When change capacity lags, new systems get imposed without buy-in and staff quietly route around them, in a business where the frontline relationship is the value proposition.

Next action: Invest in change sponsorship from funeral directors and location managers before rolling out further tools.

Fallback: No Dominant Pattern

Pattern: None of the five archetype patterns applies.

Scores are neither uniformly low nor uniformly high, and none of the three single-dimension gap patterns fits. The lowest-scoring dimensions the tool names are the best guide to where to invest next.

Next action: Raise the lowest-scoring dimension by one full stage before adding capability to the highest-scoring one.

Appendix: Maturity Framework

Industry: Deathcare — funeral homes and funeral-home networks (at-need arrangements, preneed contracts, cremation and burial services). **Owner:** Member A — Framework Designer

Why deathcare

Digital maturity in deathcare varies more than in almost any other consumer service. At one end are consolidated networks such as Service Corporation International (Dignity Memorial brand), which run centralized case management, company-wide preneed records and online arrangement tools across hundreds of locations. At the other end are direct-to-consumer, online-first providers such as Tulip Cremation (US) and Eirene (Canada), where a family can complete an entire arrangement without visiting a building. In between sit thousands of independent, often family-owned single-location homes that still run a paper case file, a whiteboard schedule and cash-or-check payment. Because "good" here means something specific (EDRS filing, preneed retrieval, insurance assignments, livestreamed services, grief aftercare), a generic maturity quiz would miss the real gaps.

The five dimensions

#	Dimension	Generic capability it calibrates	One-sentence description
1	Case & Records Infrastructure	Data infrastructure	How case files, death-certificate filings and preneed contracts are captured, governed and made retrievable across the business.
2	Family Digital Engagement	Customer interaction channels	What a grieving family can do digitally: obituaries, livestreams, payment, arrangements and aftercare.
3	Operational Automation	Operational automation	How much of scheduling, merchandise inventory and insurance-assignment processing runs on systems rather than phone calls and paper.
4	Predictive & AI Deployment	AI/ML deployment	Whether forecasting and AI tools are in production, governed for the grief context, and prioritized against a strategy.
5	Organizational Change Capacity	Organizational change capacity	Whether the organization can get funeral directors to adopt new tools and actually retire the old paper processes.

Independence check. Each dimension can score high while another scores low. A home can have a polished website and livestreams (high Family Digital Engagement) on top of paper case files (low Case & Records Infrastructure), which is exactly the "Elegant Front, Broken Back Office" pattern. A consolidated network can have centralized records and automated scheduling yet impose them on unconvinced directors (low Organizational Change Capacity).

Stage 1–5 descriptions

Stage labels used throughout: **1 Initial / Ad hoc** • **2 Developing / Reactive** • **3 Defined / Repeatable** • **4 Managed / Measured** • **5 Optimizing / Innovating**. Every stage below describes an observable state, and each builds on the one before.

1. Case & Records Infrastructure

- **Stage 1:** Each case lives in a paper folder. Death certificates are filed in person or by mail, and old preneed contracts are found by searching storage boxes, sometimes at another location.
- **Stage 2:** Contracts are produced from digital templates and preneed sales are logged in a spreadsheet, but permits, notes and filings are still handled on paper. Nobody owns the accuracy of case records.

- **Stage 3:** A case management system holds the full case at each location, and death certificates go through the state's electronic death registration system (EDRS), keyed in by hand. A named role reviews records locally.
- **Stage 4:** Case management is centralized across all locations with EDRS filing integrated into it, so any preneed contract can be pulled up company-wide. Data-quality standards are monitored across the network.
- **Stage 5:** A governed, company-wide data platform links case history, preneed contracts, payment and insurance status, and family communications. Forecasting and engagement tools are built on it rather than on separate copies.

2. Family Digital Engagement

- **Stage 1:** No website, or only a phone number and address. Payment is cash or check in person, livestreaming is not offered, and contact ends at the service.
- **Stage 2:** A static website lists services and plain-text obituaries. Livestreaming happens only if a family asks and staff improvise it; aftercare is a card mailed at a fixed interval.
- **Stage 3:** Families can share a digital obituary, sign an online guestbook and pay at-need balances online. Livestreaming is a standing service with dedicated equipment, and a standard grief-resource email sequence runs after the service.
- **Stage 4:** Families browse merchandise, pay (including financed plans) and get livestreams by default through a family portal. Aftercare check-ins are scheduled and tracked per family, with staff follow-ups prompted.
- **Stage 5:** A family can complete the entire arrangement conference and a preneed purchase online through a personalized portal. Livestreams are archived into a lasting tribute page, and aftercare is personalized automatically from the case record.

3. Operational Automation

- **Stage 1:** Staff and vehicles are scheduled by phone and a whiteboard, merchandise is reordered by calling the supplier when stock runs out, and insurance assignments are mailed as paper forms.
- **Stage 2:** A shared digital calendar and inventory spreadsheet exist but are updated by hand. Insurance assignments are still paper but tracked in a shared log, and automation ideas come from individual staff.
- **Stage 3:** Scheduling and inventory software run at each location with reorder points. Insurance assignments follow a templated digital process tracked to completion, and a named owner periodically looks for automation candidates.
- **Stage 4:** Scheduling and inventory reordering are automated across all locations, and assignments for major carriers are automated with status on a dashboard. Automation targets come from structured cross-location review.
- **Stage 5:** Staffing, vehicles and merchandise are planned from forecasted case volume and case mix. Insurance assignments run through direct carrier integration, and automation targets are found continuously from operational data.

4. Predictive & AI Deployment

- **Stage 1:** Staffing reacts to whatever calls come in. There is no AI tool, and new tools are adopted only when a vendor pitches one.
- **Stage 2:** Staffing follows a seasonal rule of thumb. A chatbot may sit on the website unmonitored, its output is looked at only if a family complains, and each location buys tools on its own.
- **Stage 3:** A forecasting tool informs staffing at a location, and one AI use case is in production after a pre-launch review. A central person or committee prioritizes proposals.
- **Stage 4:** Forecasting drives staffing and inventory across locations, and an AI family-engagement tool is in production with its usage and outcomes monitored. A named person or committee keeps reviewing it for grief-appropriate tone and accuracy, against a documented technology strategy.
- **Stage 5:** Forecasts are checked against actual outcomes and drive staffing, inventory and marketing together. Multiple AI tools run under standing governance in which appropriateness review decides whether a tool stays in use, and the

roadmap is refreshed from performance data and family feedback.

5. Organizational Change Capacity

- **Stage 1:** Ownership or IT picks new technology without funeral directors, staff learn it on the job, and the old paper process stays in use indefinitely "just in case." Nobody manages change.
- **Stage 2:** A few interested staff give informal input, there is one training session before go-live, and old processes fade out unevenly. Whoever leads a project handles the change work.
- **Stage 3:** A formal process includes funeral directors and location managers before rollout, training includes a feedback window, and retiring the old process is part of the rollout plan. A defined change-management role exists.
- **Stage 4:** Directors and location managers co-sponsor technology decisions, location-level champions support ongoing training and report into the change role, and retiring the old process is tracked as a success measure.
- **Stage 5:** Leadership goals and evaluations are tied to technology adoption, and training is refined from usage data and staff feedback. The company has a track record of fully retiring old processes, with adoption outcomes measured across the network.

Dimension calibration test

Dimension	Stage 5 reference (named organization)	Stage 1 reference
Case & Records Infrastructure	Service Corporation International (Dignity Memorial): centralized, company-wide case and preneed records	Archetype: a single-location, family-owned independent home that keeps each case in a paper folder, files death certificates in person or by mail, and stores preneed contracts in boxes
Family Digital Engagement	Tulip Cremation / Eirene: full arrangement completed online	Archetype: an independent home whose only online presence is a directory listing with a phone number; payment by cash or check, no livestreaming
Operational Automation	Large consolidators (e.g., SCI) with network-wide scheduling and procurement	Archetype: an independent home that schedules staff and the hearse on a whiteboard and reorders caskets by phoning the supplier
Predictive & AI Deployment	Consolidated networks using volume forecasting for staffing and procurement	Most independent homes: purely reactive staffing
Organizational Change Capacity	Networks running structured, champion-based rollouts of case-management software	Homes where a new system is bought but paper files are still kept in parallel